



Literature Review, Critical Analysis & Conceptual Framework — Building on Your Chapter One

Research Clinic

Chapter Two

A cross-programme clinic for postgraduate candidates across six masters' programmes, working on Chapter Two of the research proposal.

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From a Solid Chapter One to a Defensible Chapter Two

Chapter One gave you a bounded topic, named variables and an aligned problem–objectives chain. Chapter Two now puts that foundation to work.

1 Critical Review Skill

Argue, don't just describe

2 Theoretical Framework

Theory, model & framework

3 Empirical Review

What prior studies say

4 The Research Gap

The space your study fills

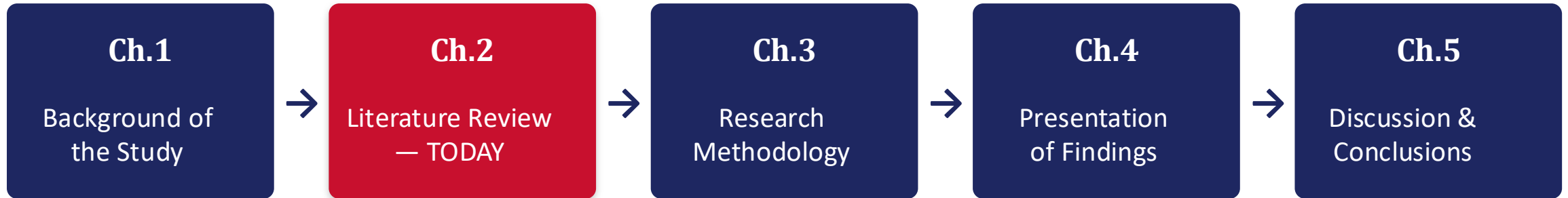
5 Conceptual Framework

Your own model of the variables

6 Operationalisation & Referencing

Measurement + APA integrity

Where Chapter Two Fits in the Dissertation Arc



Chapter Two does more than describe — it argues. It shows the theory grounding your study, what the evidence already says, exactly what is missing, your own model of how the variables relate, and how each variable will be measured.

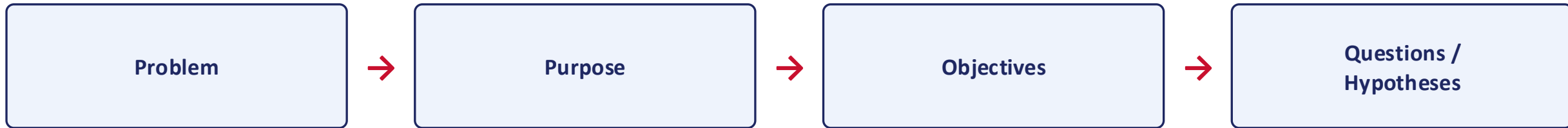
Everything here must trace forward into Chapter 3 (methodology) and Chapter 4 (analysis) — nothing in Chapter Two is decorative.

Your Variables & Your Alignment Chain

VARIABLES OF THE STUDY



YOUR ALIGNMENT CHAIN



If a reader can't trace a straight line from your problem to your last research question, the alignment has failed — and Chapter Two must extend that same line into theory and the conceptual framework.

Critical Review vs. Descriptive Summary

Descriptive Summary — avoid this

- X Lists sources one after another, by author or by date
- X Every source given roughly equal space and weight
- X Reads like a catalogue: “Smith (2020) says X. Jones (2021) says Y.”
- X No judgement of which sources matter more, or why
- X Reader cannot tell what the field agrees or disagrees on

Critical Review — aim for this

- ✓ Organised thematically around ideas, general → specific
- ✓ Space reflects a source's value to your research, not its existence
- ✓ Groups authors who agree; contrasts those who disagree
- ✓ Evaluates each contribution's quality, relevance, currency
- ✓ Builds an argument that leads the reader to your research gap

Warning Signs Your Review Reads as Descriptive

Warning Sign	The Fix
Most paragraphs open with an author's name	Open with the idea/theme; bring the citation in to support it
Findings reported but rarely compared	Ask: does this agree or conflict with what I just described?
Every paper treated as equally valuable	Weight discussion by quality and relevance of the evidence
Citations dropped in with no stated purpose	Every citation should visibly support an argument
The research gap appears suddenly at the end	Build toward the gap — don't announce it

The ultimate test: after reading your review, does the reader know what the field understands, what it disagrees about, and why the uncertainty matters? That uncertainty is where your gap lives.

Theory, Model & Framework — Related but Different

	THEORY	MODEL	FRAMEWORK
Purpose	Explains WHY a relationship exists (causal logic)	Shows HOW concepts/variables fit together	ORGANISES the theories, concepts & variables guiding a study
Nature	Abstract, propositional argument	Concrete, often visual/structural	A scaffold — broader and more flexible than either
Claims causality?	Yes — that is its core purpose	Not necessarily — mainly descriptive	No — it organises; the theories within it may
Example	Resource-Based View; Diffusion of Innovation	McKinsey 7-S; TAM; PESTEL	TOE Framework; your own conceptual framework

Strong theory always answers: ‘why would this relationship occur?’ A framework’s job is to hold your chosen theories, models and variables together for your specific study.

Selecting & Combining Theories With Care

CHOOSE A THEORY / MODEL THAT IS...

Relevance

Genuinely speaks to your phenomenon and problem

Explanatory power

Accounts for relationships in your objectives

Construct fit

Its constructs map onto your variables

Currency

Still a credible lens — not superseded

WHEN YOU NEED MORE THAN ONE THEORY

Why theories can clash

- Different ontological/epistemological roots
- Conflicting views of human agency
- Mismatched levels of analysis

How to synthesise well

- Anchor-and-support: one theory anchors, others fill gaps
- Integrative mapping: assign each theory to what it best explains
- Always state explicitly how the theories relate

Aligning Theory to Objectives, Variables & Constructs

Specific Objective	Variable / Construct	Theory / Model	Why This Theory
To establish the effect of digital adoption on customer retention	Digital Adoption (IV); Customer Retention (DV)	Technology Acceptance Model	Explains adoption via perceived usefulness & ease of use
To examine the role of employee engagement in service quality	Employee Engagement (IV); Service Quality (DV)	Social Exchange Theory	Explains reciprocity between investment and effort
To assess how firm size moderates the strategy–performance link	Firm Size (Moderator)	Resource-Based View	Explains how internal resources shape outcomes

Every objective must trace to at least one theory or model — an objective with no theoretical anchor cannot yet be examined.

A Critical Synthesis, Not a Catalogue

Thematic, Not Chronological

Organised around ideas — not by date, not author-by-author

General → Specific

Narrows steadily from the wider field to your study's focus

Contribution · Method · Limitation

Evaluate every study on all three — limitations open the gap

SEVEN PATHS FOR ORGANISING YOUR REVIEW

1

By Variable

2

By Objective

3

By Context

4

By Region

5

By Design

6

By Theme

7

By Gap

Most dissertations combine 2–3 of these paths (e.g. organise by objective, then by region within each). Many strong reviews close each thematic block with ‘what is still missing here?’ — feeding directly into the Research Gap.

Capturing Each Study — A Working Template

Author(s) & Year	Objective / Focus	Context & Design	Key Finding(s)	Limitation / Gap Pointer
Mwangi & Otieno (2023)	Mobile money use and SME growth	Kenya; cross-sectional survey	Positive, significant effect on SME turnover	Single-region sample; no moderator tested
Chen et al. (2022)	Digital adoption and firm performance	China; mixed methods	Effect strong only for firms with strong IT capability	Suggests untested moderating role of IT capability
Njoroge (2021)	Financial inclusion and SME survival	Kenya; qualitative case study	Access to credit reduces SME failure early on	Qualitative only — no generalisable quantitative test

Every row you complete should point, explicitly or implicitly, toward the gap you present in Part 4. This is your working evidence table — not the final prose.

Types of Research Gaps

1

Theoretical

A theory not yet applied, extended or tested this way

2

Empirical

Too few empirical studies on this specific relationship

3

Methodological

Prior studies relied on limited methods/designs

4

Contextual

The sector or organisational setting is unstudied

5

Population / Sample

A different population has not been examined

6

Geographical

The relationship is untested in this country/region

7

Conceptual

These variables have never been combined together

8

Temporal

Existing evidence is outdated relative to conditions

A gap is not simply 'nobody has done this before' — it must be a meaningful, justified silence in credible literature. The gap is the hinge of Chapter Two.

Presenting the Gap — What Examiners Look For

Author(s) & Year	Study Focus	Key Finding	Gap Type	How This Study Responds
Chen et al. (2022)	Digital adoption & performance in China	Effect strong only where IT capability is high	Contextual + Geographical	Tests the relationship in the Kenyan SME context
Njoroge (2021)	Financial inclusion & SME survival (qualitative)	Access to credit reduces early-stage failure	Methodological	Adds a quantitative test to strengthen generalisability
Mwangi & Otieno (2023)	Mobile money & SME growth	Positive effect on turnover, no moderator tested	Conceptual	Introduces firm size as a moderating variable

The last column is what examiners look for — every gap you name must be answered by something your study actually does.

Your Reasoned, Visual Position

1 It Is Yours

Derived from the literature, but representing the specific relationships you intend to investigate.

2 A Figure, Not Prose

A diagram shows structure and direction instantly — far faster than a paragraph.

3 It Forces Precision

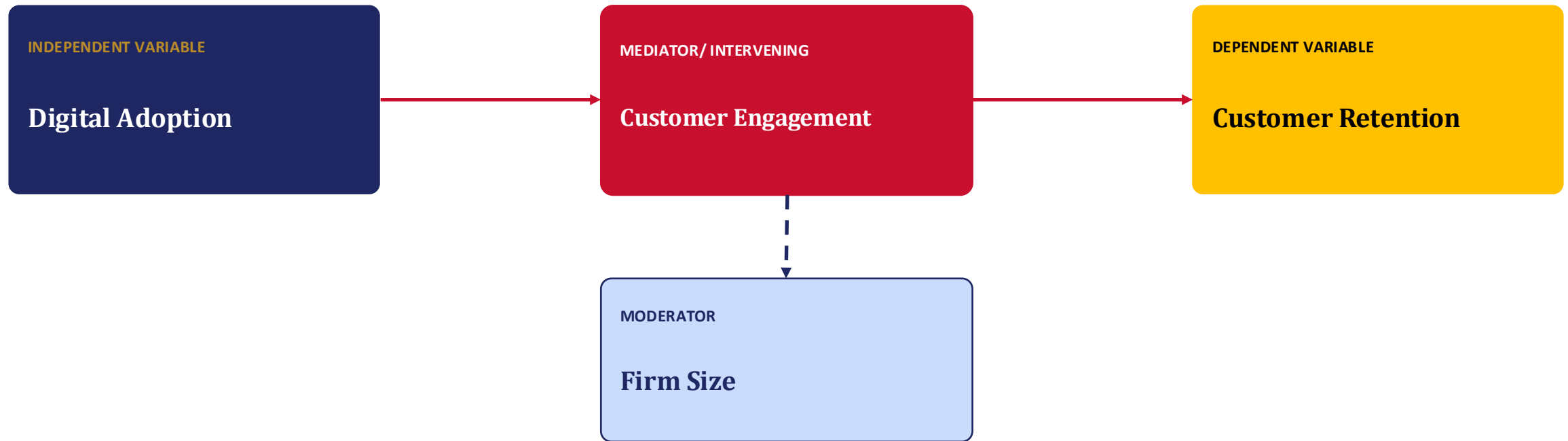
To draw the boxes and arrows you must decide exactly what role each variable plays.

4 The Visual Anchor

Examiners and readers return to it throughout the rest of the dissertation.

Built from the theory and empirical review before it — a conceptual framework with no traceable link to Parts 1–2 is not yet grounded.

Illustrative Conceptual Framework Diagram



Red arrow: hypothesised direct effect. **Red box:** mediating mechanism. **Dashed line:** moderating influence.

Every variable illustrated must appear in your objectives, correctly labelled as IV, DV, moderator, mediator or control — nothing new belongs in this figure.

Turning Constructs into Measurable Indicators



Variable	Indicators	Source	Type	Measurement
Digital Adoption	Frequency of use; range of services used	Adapted from Davis (1989)	Independent	Ordinal, 5-pt Likert
Customer Engagement	Interaction frequency; loyalty behaviour	Adapted from Vivek et al. (2012)	Mediator	Ordinal, 5-pt Likert
Customer Retention	Repeat usage rate; churn intent	Company records + survey	Dependent	Ratio & Ordinal

Every variable named in your Conceptual Framework must appear here — and nothing new should appear that wasn't in the framework.

Designing a Literature Search Strategy

1 Define Parameters

Boundaries from your research question — what's in scope, what isn't

2 Generate Key Words

Terms from your objectives; include synonyms and related terms

3 Choose Sources

Library databases, Google Scholar, SU+ repository for dissertations

4 Set Inclusion/Exclusion

Date range, geography, study type, language — before screening

5 Search & Screen

Boolean logic (AND/OR/NOT); titles/abstracts, then full text

6 Refine & Repeat

A spiral, not a one-off — revisit as your topic sharpens

Design your search deliberately — not by accident. A defensible review starts with a defensible search.

Evaluating Sources, APA & Academic Integrity

TYPES OF LITERATURE

Primary

Journal articles, theses, reports — most authoritative

Secondary

Textbooks, review articles — useful for orientation

Tertiary

Indexes, encyclopaedias — good starting point only

Evaluate every source on relevance, currency and quality.

APA 7TH & ACADEMIC INTEGRITY

- **In-text citations:**
- author–date(–page); every citation resolves to a reference-list entry, and vice versa.
- **Plagiarism:**
- presenting others' words, data or ideas as your own — including close paraphrasing without citation.
- **Similarity report:**
- required on proposal and final dissertation, must fall below 15%.

CITATION MANAGER

Zotero — recommended

Free, best group-library support, reliable APA 7th output. Mendeley and EndNote are workable alternatives.

Chapter Two Coherence & Strathmore Compliance Checklist

Coherence (Content)

- ✓ Every objective traces to at least one theory in the Theoretical Framework
- ✓ The Empirical Review is organised deliberately — not a list of summaries
- ✓ Each study reviewed points, explicitly or implicitly, toward a gap
- ✓ The Gap table names the gap type(s) and how your study responds
- ✓ The Conceptual Framework has only variables in your objectives, correctly labelled
- ✓ The Operationalisation table accounts for every framework variable

Strathmore Compliance (Form)

- ✓ Checked against Strathmore's SU Guide to Research (Appendix G)
- ✓ Margins, spacing, page numbering, heading levels per SU Guide §2.0, §6.0
- ✓ Every claim referenced in APA 7th — no paragraph left uncited
- ✓ Checked against your own programme's specific variations for Chapter 2
- ✓ Table/figure numbering & sourcing follows the SU Guide convention
- ✓ Similarity report run and below 15% before submission

Before Your Next Clinic Session

- 1 Theory/Model matrix: each objective mapped to its theory or model
- 2 A draft Empirical Review table with a minimum of 8 studies, organised along a chosen path
- 3 A draft Research Gap table naming the gap type(s) your study responds to
- 4 A hand-drawn or digital Conceptual Framework diagram, correctly labelled
- 5 A draft Operationalisation table covering every variable in the framework
- 6 Your search strategy paragraph and citation-manager library, set to APA 7th

Come with a draft, not just notes — run the self-review checklist on your own work before you bring it.